

Off the Shelf



Steel Beasts

Too much realism

Games are getting more realistic these days, AI is more intelligent and graphics better. A well-designed game should never get too real. Good designers make games that never get so complex, that it's no longer fun to play them. Unfortunately, *Steel Beasts* is not one of them.

This game is a tank simulator. Which means you'll be put into a tank and either run over, or blow away anyone who gets in your way. Driving around a 60-ton steel box can be tank-loads of fun. However, to actually get into a battle with one of these, you'll have to sit through approximately 40 tutorials—20 for each tank i.e., the US M1A1 Abrams and the German Leopard 2A4. If that isn't enough to kill off your interest in the game, there's more



CREATE AND RIDE: Create a locale, lay your tracks and ride through the greens

to come.

Certain aspects of the graphics are pre-historic—your tank will 'skim' over the surface of a wide river, though at reduced speed. Though, in all other respects this simulator comes close to the real thing.

You'll actually begin to appreciate the

game's complexity, when you drive the tank and fire a few rounds. The chain of command and the weapon systems are very realistic. Which translates into several keys and combinations to remember.

If you choose to be the gunner, all you have to do is fire, but opting for the Tank Commander's role lands you with the responsibility of planning your platoon's strategys—which involves formations and combat tactics.

The objectives are equivalent to actual battle situations, so if you're looking to grab hold of a big gun and blow the stuffing out of your opponents, this is the last game on earth you should play. However, if you plan on buying a tank in the future, this is the perfect tool to get some lessons!

Genre: Strategy First ■ **Developer:** eSim Games ■ **Distributor:** e-Xpress Interactive Pvt Ltd ■ **Phone:** 022-28870017 ■ **Web site:** www.esimgames.com
Price: Rs 499 ■ **System requirements:** 266 MHz CPU, 32 MB RAM, 2 MB video card, 250 MB hard disk space, CD-ROM drive, Windows 9x\Me\2000, DirectX 7 ■ **Rating:** ★★☆☆☆



GI Combat Episode 1: Battle of Normandy

War-weary

GI Combat is a real-time strategy tactical war-game set in the Normandy landings during World War II. The objective of the game is to control squads of infantry and armour, and defend or capture positions—depending on which side you choose to be, German or Allied.

GIC feels like an extremely watered-down version of the tactical RTS sub-genre. You only have a few tens of units at your disposal at any given time, most of whom just wait to be obliterated by the enemy.

The graphics are a sorry sight, with incredibly tiny square maps that all look alike, and only so many trees and building



WATCH THE PIXELS BURN: Looking down, things look pretty hot

types to go around. The only difference between maps is the surrounding environment—grassy plains or coastlines. The awk-

ward camera angles make it impossible to view the bottom corner of the map.

The tutorial does not prepare you for the game, and somehow, units never seem to function properly. The German sharpshooter is the first to die, command units run away, and the enemy seems to have better aim and ability. The only saving grace are mortar teams, which kill squads from several hundred metres away, until they run out of ammunition. You have to huddle together and hope to put up a fight.

The lack of an in-game save feature is painful, and only hardcore fans of the RTS genre might find this game appealing.

Genre: Strategy First ■ **Developer:** Freedom Games Inc ■ **Distributor:** e-Xpress Interactive Pvt Ltd ■ **Phone:** 022-28870017
Web site: www.gicombat.com ■ **Price:** Rs 699 ■ **System requirements:** 600 MHz CPU, 128 MB RAM, Windows 98\2000\XP, 4x CD-ROM drive, 16 MB video card. **Rating:** ★★☆☆☆

